General relativity

I fall off the roof -
Does the ground pull me or am I -
Oh, what do I care?

T-Recs

Hey it's Spotify Wrapped season so here are some song recs:

Fought & Lost (Sam Ryder feat. Brian May)
ڈھونڈ لیا (Sherine)
Nilapakshi - sad ver. (Neha S. Nair, Sushin Shyam, Vinayak Sasikumar)
Kids (Robbie Williams, Kylie Minogue)
Keanu Reeves (Logic)
Stained (Linkin Park)

P.S. If you want to trip out over something, go listen to *Daawat-e-Ishq* and *Haanikaarak Bapu* back-to-back. Focus on the choruses. Be amazed.

Editor's Note

Optimism, much as I hate to admit it, is not without its benefits. A severe case of it, however, is quite worrisome. What I refer to is the bottomless, unhinged sort of positivity that the average life coach or self-help book prescribes. It gets you nowhere. Neither, admittedly, does complaining. The latter, however, is a start. It exposes problems, and identification is the first step to a solution. I complain loudly and proudly. I have no pet peeves - my peeves exist in the wilderness, unafraid of exposure. Does their presence bother you? Complain about it.

I make a fuss when in the here and now, I lack energy and/or time to actually do something about them. Perhaps the last sentence was a little misleading. I do not oppose the idea of initiative. By all means, take matters into your own hands. If you are the type to wait around for no one, be my guest. But do not hesitate to complain on occasion. Whinge when you can, for there is little shame in the blame game. Complaint is the controlled chain reaction of negativity - you will find that it is quite therapeutic.

The Desolation of Smog

Given Delhi's state right now, I may have chosen the wrong phrase to get stuck in my head. It is neither appropriate nor linguistically coherent - but maybe that's just pedantry. What on earth is a breath of 'fresh' air? There is air, and then there is more air. Bread can be fresh, so can paper. Even ideas can be fresh. Air, however, is in constant flux. Whether we are in a wasteland or in a Tibetan monastery, we are breathing millennia-old air. There is nothing fresh about it. Dirty and clean air exist, but both are aged the same.

Some may say, "Oh, but the implication is obvious." And to that I say - there is no greater enemy to etymology than human flakiness. Take the word probably, for instance. It comes from a Latin word meaning 'provable by experiment'. After centuries of people bandying it around, it has been reduced to the limp, indecisive form of today. Our perpetual unreliability has thus been brushed under a carpet labelled 'semantic shifts'.

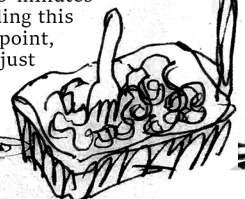
The only coherent interpretation of fresh air would thus be an oxygen cylinder, a nebulizer, or an inhaler. Hardly usable in a daily context. The way things are going, however, that may well change... which would then defeat this argument, but at what cost?

The farce that is Maggi points

Delhi has several good points. Maggi points are not one of them. They seem to me the most obviously fraudulent business model ever conceived. And yet people seem to fall for it with alarming readiness.

On the whole, Delhi's street food culture is great fun. Hunger is quite the unifying factor (hardly an original observation) and I enjoy seeing it in action. But Maggi points stick out like a horrible, gangrenous, sore thumb. The USP of Maggi noodles is efficiency of time, cost and effort. For college-goers in particular, it is a cheap, easy, even sustainable expression of their independence. Allowing a business to grow out of such a product is pure stupidity. It's like paying a guy at a buffet to serve you food. The concept alone is ridiculous - and the less said about the prices the better. The masalas added to each variant cause such negligible changes in taste that they might as well not be there. An argument might be made for slapping a slice of cheese on top - but in the long run, doing this on your own is ultimately more efficient.

It's probably taken you two minutes to get this far. If you're reading this while standing at a Maggi point, congratulations - you've just been conned.



A photocopy shop conspiracy

Privacy is of great importance these days. Actually, no, the better way to put it would be to say that privacy is more of a concern these days since it never used to be much trouble to keep things private. Nowadays we are supposed to constantly remain vigilant in case our data comes under threat. No one is to be trusted.

And then there are photocopy shops.

If I wanted to steal people's data, I'd start a photocopy shop. Aadhaar, PAN, passport, the works - you name it, the photocopy shops have it. We trust them, too. Implicitly. Once I'm done typing this, where am I off to? You know it- the photocopy shop. We have an unspoken, unjustifiable, yet unshakeable trust in the photocopy people. We do not know who they are, nor do we bother to try finding out. And yet, they know far too much about us. Every time we leave town, they know. How? They printed out our tickets. There is little about our lives that the photocopy people cannot piece together.

The issue with this complaint of mine is that I write this fully aware of how indispensable they are. I have no alternative for them. I went to them today. I will go again tomorrow. All the while wondering how on earth they haven't taken over the world yet.